THE ART OF BEING HIMANTA

Ever since he left the Congress to join the BJP in 2015, the Assam CM has emerged as the new poster boy of Hindutva politics



MANASH DAS

- Several of his government's missions such as the drive against drug abuse, cattle smuggling, illegal encroachment on public land, unauthorised madrasas and child marriages, are seen to be targeting Muslims. His public statements on issues such as 'love jihad' and Muslim population growth have made him quite popular among the Hindutva brigade
- From sheltering Maharashtra's rebel Shiv Sena leaders to facilitating the defection of eight Goa Congress MLAs to brokering peace between West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee and then governor (and now V-P) Jagdeep Dhankhar, Sarma has been the go-to person for BJP's shadow politics. He has been instrumental in wiping out the Congress in the Northeast, primarily through his moles in his former party
- Sarma seems ready to hit back at anyone making offensive remarks against PM Narendra Modi. His police team arrested Gujarat MLA Jignesh Mewani in April last year and Congress spokesperson Pawan Khera in February for making "derogatory" comments against Modi
- Transparent intent and delivery of services have been the trademarks of the Sarma model of governance. Cabinet meetings are mandatory every week and all decisions are immediately made public. Land reforms have been a particular focus area



- The CM also keeps his administration separate from his political grandstanding. His eviction drives have hurt even the indigenous Assamese. On February 27, 300 Assamese families were evicted from public land in Guwahati and two temples demolished

he said, in a categorical reference to Assam's Muslim population. For the record, 80 per cent of the population of Dhubri district in Assam is Muslim.

Many of the Sarma government's social reform drives, therefore, have complemented his aggressive pro-Hindu stand, with the Muslim community mostly bearing the brunt of it—from police action against drug traffickers, cow smugglers, illegal encroachers and those involved in child marriages to shutting down of government madrasas and demolition of illegal ones. More importantly, Sarma backs up his actions with research and data. "He reads a lot on diverse subjects and has a photographic memory. Give him a 10-page note and he will in one glance not only grasp the gist but also point out mistakes if any in data or content," says Prasanta Protim Kathkotia, principal private secretary to the CM. Recently, he read up a dozen books on Ahom general Lachit Barphukan and then challenged historians with documents claiming that a character, Ismail Siddique a.k.a. Bagh Hazarika, who fought alongside Lachit against the Mughals, did not exist. For ages, Bagh Hazarika has been celebrated as a symbol of Assam's secular culture.

That Sarma is directly accessible to people through social media platforms also helps him receive inputs from the ground on issues. Assam DGP G.P. Singh points out how the CM had approached him in October last year—three months before the child marriage drive—to prepare a detailed action plan on the social menace. The police had more than half a dozen meetings with NGOs before starting penal action against the perpetrators.

Sarma is rather upfront about his objective: "*Miyas* (a pejorative for immigrant Muslims in Assam) are a threat to Assam's culture and identity." When a group of people started a private museum in Goalpara in October last year to showcase Miya culture, Sarma was quick to shut it down. Similarly, in January, when journalists asked the CM about Bajrang Dal activists vandalising a cinema hall in Guwahati protesting the release of Shah Rukh Khan-starrer *Pathaan*, he retorted: "Who is Shah Rukh Khan?"

Those who have followed Sarma's political journey understand the political dynamics of such statements. He often makes "well calculated, casual sounding" statements with an eye on his vote base. More than questioning Shah Rukh's credentials, the comments that followed revealed his intent. "There are many Shah Rukh Khans in Assam," he said. It was aimed at provoking the Hindu and Assamese reactions that such names now evoke in the state. Showcasing Shah Rukh as a threat to regional cinema, he sought to play the Assamese pride card.



"There is no strategy behind what he is doing. He is a man with bad taste and intent. Whatever he does is a reflection of his personality. He is not afraid of the consequences, so he does as he pleases"

RAKIBUL HUSSAIN
Congress MLA, Assam